ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · April 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Kansas City	74.3
#2	A+	Raleigh	72.4
#3	A+	Hartford	68.6
#4	A+	Las Vegas	68.2
#5	A	Austin	65.4
#6	A	Birmingham	64.2
#7	A	Salt Lake City	63.8

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Portland	22.8
#49	C-	Washington DC	28.7
#48	C-	Baltimore	29.6
#47	C-	Richmond	30.7
#46	C-	Jacksonville	31.9
#45	C	Chicago	34.3
#44	C	Minneapolis	34.6

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	9 cities
B+ / B / B-	23 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, LFP, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · April 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
1	**Kansas City** Kansas City	A+	74.3	3.5%	+7.0%	+1.4%	N/A	45 days
2	**Raleigh** Raleigh-Cary	A+	72.4	3.0%	+4.0%	+1.7%	N/A	46 days
3	**Hartford** Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	68.6	2.7%	+0.1%	+1.9%	N/A	39 days
4	**Las Vegas** Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A+	68.2	5.2%	+6.7%	+1.7%	N/A	52 days
5	**Austin** Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	65.4	3.2%	+5.8%	+1.4%	N/A	53 days
6	**Birmingham** Birmingham	A	64.2	2.2%	-0.5%	+0.5%	N/A	56 days
7	**Salt Lake City** Salt Lake City-Murray	A	63.8	3.4%	+4.0%	+0.7%	N/A	45 days
8	**Dallas** Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	A-	62.9	3.6%	+4.4%	+1.0%	N/A	48 days
9	**Nashville** Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A-	61.7	3.0%	+2.3%	+0.4%	N/A	53 days
10	**Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh	B+	57.9	3.6%	+7.0%	+0.3%	N/A	65 days
11	**Los Angeles** Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B+	55.5	4.8%	+5.4%	+1.8%	N/A	45 days
12	**San Francisco** San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B+	55.0	4.1%	+5.5%	+0.7%	N/A	29 days
13	**Houston** Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	54.9	4.2%	+4.1%	+0.7%	N/A	50 days
14	**Cincinnati** Cincinnati	B	54.9	3.6%	+0.6%	+0.3%	N/A	45 days
15	**Atlanta** Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B	54.2	N/A	+6.5%	N/A	N/A	51 days
16	**Denver** Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B	54.0	3.6%	+4.7%	-0.1%	N/A	38 days
17	**Fresno** Fresno	B	53.4	8.2%	+8.4%	+1.9%	N/A	51 days
18	**Memphis** Memphis	B	53.2	4.0%	+6.1%	-0.3%	N/A	62 days
19	**San Jose** San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B	51.7	4.0%	+0.7%	+1.7%	N/A	24 days
20	**New York** New York Newark-Jersey City	B	50.7	4.5%	+5.5%	+0.1%	N/A	51 days
21	**Charlotte** Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	B	50.4	3.6%	-1.3%	+0.8%	N/A	49 days
22	**San Diego** San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B	50.3	4.4%	+4.6%	+0.7%	N/A	38 days
23	**Miami** Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	49.5	3.5%	+8.4%	-0.7%	N/A	74 days
24	**Columbus** Columbus	B-	49.4	3.6%	+3.0%	+0.3%	N/A	41 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
25	**Cleveland** Cleveland	B-	49.0	3.4%	-0.8%	+0.6%	N/A	55 days
26	**Philadelphia** Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B-	48.3	N/A	N/A	+0.3%	N/A	43 days
27	**Phoenix** Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	48.1	3.5%	N/A	-0.3%	N/A	54 days
28	**Providence** Providence-Warwick	B-	48.1	4.3%	+2.8%	+0.6%	N/A	48 days
29	**Louisville** Louisville-Jefferson County	B-	47.4	3.1%	+2.4%	-0.2%	N/A	45 days
30	**Riverside** Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	B-	44.8	5.1%	+6.7%	+0.9%	N/A	54 days
31	**Seattle** Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	44.2	5.0%	+9.0%	-0.1%	N/A	34 days
32	**Sacramento** Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	B-	44.2	4.8%	+3.0%	+1.0%	N/A	39 days
33	**San Antonio** San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	43.7	3.7%	+3.4%	+0.4%	N/A	61 days
34	**Tampa** Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	C+	43.3	4.6%	+8.8%	-0.2%	N/A	66 days
35	**Oklahoma City** Oklahoma City	C+	42.5	3.6%	+5.4%	-0.5%	N/A	55 days
36	**Indianapolis** Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	42.0	2.5%	+4.0%	-0.7%	N/A	51 days
37	**Grand Rapids** Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C+	41.4	4.0%	+3.9%	-0.4%	N/A	44 days
38	**Orlando** Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	C+	40.1	4.4%	N/A	+0.5%	N/A	67 days
39	**St. Louis** St. Louis	C+	38.8	3.5%	+1.4%	+0.2%	N/A	46 days
40	**Boston** Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C+	38.1	3.9%	+3.4%	N/A	N/A	30 days
41	**Virginia Beach** Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C	37.7	3.6%	+10.1%	-0.4%	N/A	36 days
42	**Milwaukee** Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	35.5	3.1%	+3.5%	-0.8%	N/A	33 days
43	**Detroit** Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C	35.2	4.7%	+1.6%	-0.2%	N/A	45 days
44	**Minneapolis** Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	34.6	N/A	+1.5%	-0.1%	N/A	36 days
45	**Chicago** Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C	34.3	4.5%	+4.0%	+0.3%	N/A	35 days
46	**Jacksonville** Jacksonville	C-	31.9	4.6%	+6.4%	-0.5%	N/A	58 days
47	**Richmond** Richmond	C-	30.7	3.3%	+5.4%	-0.4%	N/A	39 days
48	**Baltimore** Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C-	29.6	3.6%	+3.0%	-1.5%	N/A	37 days
49	**Washington DC** Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C-	28.7	3.8%	+1.9%	N/A	N/A	N/A
50	**Portland** Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	D	22.8	4.9%	+5.0%	-1.8%	N/A	49 days

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

74.3th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	96
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	85
Cost of Living	12% weight	76
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	89
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	62
Housing Access	5% weight	4
Office Economy	3% weight	38

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+7.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.4%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.
N/A
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS
+5.4%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
45 days
median, -11.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an A+ grade, driven by its excellent economic character, with top-tier nonfarm employment growth of +1.39% YoY and labor force growth of +2.10% YoY. The city's wage growth of +6.97% YoY indicates that workers are benefiting from this growth, while employers face increasing labor costs.

The city's affordable cost of living is being tested by a fast-moving housing market, with days on market at 45 days and decreasing by -11.8% YoY. This demand surge is driven by genuine employment growth, as evidenced by above-average building permits growth of +5.41% YoY. The housing market's rapid pace poses a relocation challenge for new hires.

Kansas City offers businesses a thriving economy with rapid job creation and a growing workforce, but the fast-moving housing market poses a significant relocation challenge. The city's affordability advantage is eroding as demand outpaces housing supply, impacting its attractiveness to businesses and workers. Businesses should consider the potential impact on talent attraction and retention when evaluating Kansas City as a location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

72.4th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	92
Unemployment	20% weight	81
Wage Growth	15% weight	43
Cost of Living	12% weight	80
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	36
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	85
Housing Access	5% weight	43
Office Economy	3% weight	98

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.0%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.7%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+38.8%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**46 days**	median, +4.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Raleigh earns an A+ overall grade, driven by its exceptionally tight labor market with a 3.00% unemployment rate and 1.70% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth. The city has a highly concentrated professional workforce, ranking in the 98th percentile for office and professional worker share. This positions Raleigh as an economically expanding market with a deep talent pool, making it attractive for knowledge-economy businesses and headquarters.

The labor force is growing slowly, at 0.53% year-over-year, which constrains hiring capacity and exacerbates the competitive labor market. The cost of living is among the most affordable, with a score of 1.42. The housing market is stabilizing, with days on market increasing by 4.5% year-over-year to 46 days, and building permits rising 38.82% year-over-year, indicating a healthy normalization.

Raleigh offers businesses a unique combination of talent, affordability, and economic momentum, making it an excellent location for companies seeking to tap into a deep professional workforce. The primary risk lies in labor market constraints limiting hiring capacity, which businesses must consider when evaluating Raleigh as a potential location, weighing the benefits of its strong economy against the challenges of a competitive labor market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

68.6th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	98
Unemployment	20% weight	94
Wage Growth	15% weight	6
Cost of Living	12% weight	48
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	94
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	32
Housing Access	5% weight	98
Office Economy	3% weight	43

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, +30.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Hartford earns an A+ grade, driven by its remarkably tight labor market with an unemployment rate of 2.70% and labor force growth of 2.77% year-over-year. The city's nonfarm employment growth of 1.88% year-over-year indicates strong job creation. This momentum is driven by a highly competitive labor market where businesses face significant hiring competition and workers have substantial leverage.

Beneath the surface of economic strength, wage growth has been stagnant, with hourly earnings increasing by only 0.13% year-over-year, a bottom-tier performance. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 30.0% year-over-year to an average of 39 days, and building permits declining by 12.70% year-over-year. This slowdown indicates a potential housing supply squeeze that could impact affordability and workforce attraction.

Hartford offers businesses a highly competitive and expanding economic environment with strong job growth, but the primary risk lies in the potential for a housing supply squeeze and stagnant wage growth, which could erode the city's attractiveness to workers and impact consumer spending. Businesses must carefully weigh these factors to determine whether Hartford's economic momentum can overcome its emerging challenges.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #4 OF 50

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

A+

EXCELLENT

68.2th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	94
Unemployment	20% weight	30
Wage Growth	15% weight	81
Cost of Living	12% weight	52
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	96
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	45
Housing Access	5% weight	76
Office Economy	3% weight	85

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-9.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	52 days	median, +18.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Las Vegas earns an A+ grade, driven by its exceptional economic performance. The city's labor market is characterized by strong growth, with nonfarm employment increasing by 1.7% year-over-year and a labor force expansion of 3.24% year-over-year. Wages are rising rapidly, with hourly earnings growing by 6.67% year-over-year, indicating a highly competitive job market.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 18.2% year-over-year to an average of 52 days. The unemployment rate of 5.2% is elevated, indicating some labor market slack. The city's 85th percentile ranking for office and professional worker share demonstrates a deep professional talent pool, a significant advantage for knowledge-economy businesses.

Las Vegas offers businesses a highly competitive and growing labor market, with a strong pipeline of skilled workers. The primary risk is labor cost pressures due to rapid wage growth, which could impact businesses' bottom lines. With its strong employment trends and talented workforce, Las Vegas remains an attractive location for businesses, despite some signs of housing market slowdown.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #5 OF 50

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

65.4th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	57
Unemployment	20% weight	77
Wage Growth	15% weight	72
Cost of Living	12% weight	94
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	62
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	11
Housing Access	5% weight	71
Office Economy	3% weight	96

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.2%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+5.8%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.4%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-29.4%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**53 days**	median, +20.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Austin earns an overall grade of A, driven by its exceptional labor market performance. The city's low unemployment rate of 3.20% and above-average labor force growth of 1.01% YoY indicate a healthy labor market. Austin also boasts a top-tier cost of living composite score of 1.02, making it one of the most affordable metros, and has a deep professional talent pool, with a 96th percentile rank for office and professional worker concentration.

The city's housing supply metrics, however, are a concern. Building permits are declining sharply by 29.44% YoY, a bottom-tier performance that signals potential future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulty. Days on market are increasing by 20.4% YoY, with homes taking an average of 53 days to sell, indicating a slowing market. This decline in housing supply poses a risk to the city's economic momentum, particularly given the average employment growth of 1.36% YoY.

Austin offers businesses a unique combination of affordability, a deep professional talent pool, and a healthy labor market, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses and HQ locations. The primary risk lies in the city's declining housing supply, which will impact future workforce attraction and affordability. Decision-makers should carefully consider this risk when evaluating Austin as a business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

Birmingham

Birmingham

A

VERY GOOD

64.2th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	88
Unemployment	20% weight	98
Wage Growth	15% weight	4
Cost of Living	12% weight	26
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	66
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	92
Housing Access	5% weight	31
Office Economy	3% weight	53

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**2.2%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**-0.5%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.5%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+55.2%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**56 days**	median, +3.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham earns a grade of A- due to its highly competitive labor market, with an unemployment rate of 2.20% and a 0.52% year-over-year increase in nonfarm employment. The city's labor force growth is 1.06% year-over-year, outpacing the national average. This strong labor market dynamics indicate an economically expanding market.

The city's housing market is competitive, with homes selling in 56 days on average, but it is slowing, with a 3.7% year-over-year increase in days on market. This slowdown occurs alongside a 55.25% year-over-year increase in building permits, indicating a normalization of the market. Wage growth is stagnant, with a -0.46% year-over-year change, limiting workers' leverage despite the tight labor market.

Birmingham offers a highly dynamic economic environment, with a strong labor market and aggressive housing supply growth. The tight labor market poses a risk for businesses, which may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent due to stagnant wage growth. With a highly competitive labor market and expanding economy, businesses must navigate these challenges to succeed in Birmingham.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A

VERY GOOD

63.8th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	86
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	49
Cost of Living	12% weight	67
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	40
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	68
Housing Access	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	94

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.4%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.7%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+14.7%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**45 days**	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Salt Lake City earns an overall grade of A, driven by its strong economic character and top-tier nonfarm employment growth of +0.74% YoY. The city's deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 94th percentile for office and professional worker concentration, supports this growth. The below-average cost of living, with a composite index of 1.83, adds to the city's appeal, making it attractive for businesses and workers.

The housing market is highly competitive, with homes selling at an average of 45 days on market, ranking in the 26th percentile. This poses a barrier to talent attraction, as relocating workers face significant time pressure and competition. The city's above-average building permit growth of +14.73% YoY indicates that housing supply is keeping pace with demand, mitigating some of the pressure.

Salt Lake City offers businesses a thriving economy with a deep talent pool and low cost of living. The highly competitive housing market poses a risk, as relocating workers may struggle to secure housing quickly, potentially impacting talent attraction and retention efforts. With its strong economic fundamentals, the city remains an attractive location for businesses, despite the challenges in the housing market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

A-

GOOD

62.9th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	78
Unemployment	20% weight	70
Wage Growth	15% weight	53
Cost of Living	12% weight	87
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	43
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	17
Housing Access	5% weight	47
Office Economy	3% weight	92

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-21.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	48 days	median, +6.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area earns an overall grade of A- and ranks in the 62.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with its strong labor market being the single most important takeaway. This strong performance is underpinned by a healthy labor market, with an unemployment rate of 3.60% and above-average nonfarm employment growth of 0.98% year-over-year. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.28 places it in the top tier for affordability.

The city's office and professional worker share is a significant strength, with the city ranking in the 92nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool that can support knowledge-economy businesses. The sharp decline in building permits, down 20.96% year-over-year, raises concerns about a potential housing supply squeeze, which could lead to affordability and workforce attraction challenges if left unaddressed.

Dallas offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, high affordability, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for investment. The primary risk lies in the potential housing supply squeeze, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and create challenges for workforce attraction if not mitigated through targeted development and planning initiatives.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A-

GOOD

61.7th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	65
Unemployment	20% weight	87
Wage Growth	15% weight	21
Cost of Living	12% weight	41
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	98
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	47
Housing Access	5% weight	53
Office Economy	3% weight	89

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.0%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+2.3%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.4%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-8.9%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**53 days**	median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville earns an A- grade, driven by its strong labor market and deep professional talent pool. The city's 3.0% unemployment rate indicates a tight labor market, where businesses face significant hiring competition and workers have leverage. This is further reinforced by the 3.42% year-over-year growth in the labor force, signaling a rapidly expanding workforce supply.

Nashville's office and professional worker share ranks in the 89th percentile, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses and headquarters. Wage growth is 2.31% year-over-year, which is sluggish and indicates a lower cost environment for employers but potentially weak worker bargaining power. Employment growth is above average at 0.41% year-over-year, while the housing market is slowing, with homes taking 12.8% more days to sell than last year.

Nashville offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, deep professional talent pool, and above-average job growth, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The primary risk is the potential for hiring challenges due to the exceptionally low unemployment rate, which could constrain business expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #10 OF 50

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

57.9th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	51
Unemployment	20% weight	55
Wage Growth	15% weight	87
Cost of Living	12% weight	78
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	49
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	38
Housing Access	5% weight	20
Office Economy	3% weight	62

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-10.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	65 days	median, +4.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns a B+ grade, driven by its top-tier 7.00% year-over-year wage growth, indicating a strong labor market. The city's cost of living composite score is 1.42, below average, making it an attractive location for businesses and workers. An above-average professional workforce further reinforces the city's economic character.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 4.8% year-over-year to an average of 65 days, and building permits declining by -10.55% year-over-year. This slowdown could indicate a genuine erosion of demand, rather than a healthy normalization of the market. The city's strong economic indicators make this dynamic noteworthy, as it may impact Pittsburgh's affordability advantage.

Pittsburgh offers a unique combination of strong wage growth, an affordable cost of living, and a professional workforce, making it attractive for investment. The primary risk lies in the potential erosion of demand in the housing market, which could impact the city's long-term affordability and attractiveness to relocating workers, with 7.00% wage growth and a cost of living score of 1.42 being key factors.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.5th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	80
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	66
Cost of Living	12% weight	4
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	47
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	81
Housing Access	5% weight	57
Office Economy	3% weight	79

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.8%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+5.4%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.8%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+20.2%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**45 days**	median, +7.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim earns a B+ grade, driven by its strong labor market with nonfarm employment growth of +1.83% YoY and solid wage growth of +5.44% YoY. The city's cost of living composite score is 5.63, placing it in the bottom tier, which constrains talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. This high cost of living is a significant concern for businesses.

The housing market is expanding, with building permits growing aggressively at +20.24% YoY, indicating a potential long-term improvement in affordability. Homes take an average of 45 days to sell, with days on market increasing by +7.1% YoY. This indicates a stabilizing force in the market, driven by strong employment growth and rising permits.

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim offers a strong and expanding labor market, with solid wage growth and an aggressively expanding housing supply. The high cost of living is the primary risk, impacting talent acquisition and consumer spending power. Businesses should factor this into their location decision, considering the need for tailored compensation strategies to attract and retain talent in this market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.0th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	76
Unemployment	20% weight	47
Wage Growth	15% weight	70
Cost of Living	12% weight	15
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	32
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	96
Housing Access	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	55

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.1%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. **N/A** working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS **+86.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **29 days** median, -6.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Francisco earns a B+ grade, with its strong job market and high wage growth being the most important takeaway. The city's nonfarm employment growth of +0.65% YoY and solid wage growth of +5.54% YoY indicate a healthy expansion, with businesses and workers benefiting from a strong job market. San Francisco has a cost of living composite of 4.52, ranking in the bottom tier, making it one of the most expensive metros.

The housing market is driven by strong demand, with days on market at 29 days and decreasing by -6.5% YoY. The top-tier building permits growth of +86.01% YoY indicates an aggressive expansion of housing supply. Labor force growth is +0.43% YoY, below average, but not a significant constraint given the overall job market strength.

San Francisco offers businesses a thriving job market with strong wage growth, but the high cost of living and intense housing competition pose a primary risk, hindering talent attraction and retention. Companies must weigh the benefits of a dynamic economy against the challenges of accommodating employees in one of the most expensive cities in the country, with a cost of living composite that ranks in the bottom tier.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #13 OF 50

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B

AVERAGE

54.9th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	59
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	51
Cost of Living	12% weight	96
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	57
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	30
Housing Access	5% weight	61
Office Economy	3% weight	64

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.2%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.1%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.7%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-12.9%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**50 days**	median, +11.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Houston earns a B grade, driven by its high affordability ranking as one of the most affordable metros. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.01 ranks in the 96th percentile, offering a strong cost advantage for businesses and residents. This affordability is offset by an elevated unemployment rate of 4.20%, signaling labor market slack and weakened local consumer demand.

The housing market shows signs of demand erosion, with days on market increasing by 11.1% year-over-year to an average of 50 days. Building permits have declined by 12.89% year-over-year, indicating that housing supply is not keeping pace with demand. The city's above-average office and professional worker share, ranking in the 64th percentile, is a positive for office-dependent businesses.

Houston's attractive cost structure is a significant draw for businesses, with its high affordability ranking being a major advantage. However, the city's slowing housing market and declining building permits pose a risk to local consumer demand and labor market vitality, making labor market weakness the primary concern.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

B

AVERAGE

54.9th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	61
Unemployment	20% weight	85
Wage Growth	15% weight	8
Cost of Living	12% weight	28
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	15
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	94
Housing Access	5% weight	92
Office Economy	3% weight	81

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+0.6%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.3%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+57.5%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**45 days**	median, +21.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns a B grade, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.60% being the most important takeaway about this city. The city's nonfarm employment growth remains above average, at 0.30% year-over-year, signaling a healthy economic expansion. However, this is paired with a shrinking civilian labor force, which contracted by 0.79% year-over-year, indicating a structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their headcount.

The low unemployment rate is accompanied by stagnant wage growth of 0.55% year-over-year, indicating that workers do not have as much leverage as the headline rate implies. The city's housing market is slowing, with homes taking 21.6% more days to sell than last year, resulting in an average of 45 days on market. This slowdown is accompanied by an aggressive expansion of housing supply, with building permits increasing by 57.47% year-over-year.

Cincinnati offers businesses a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking in the 81st percentile, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The city's tight labor market, with a shrinking civilian labor force, poses a primary risk that may constrain hiring and expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

B

AVERAGE

54.2th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	71
Unemployment	20% weight	19
Wage Growth	15% weight	79
Cost of Living	12% weight	74
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	34
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Housing Access	5% weight	45
Office Economy	3% weight	40

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	N/A	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	N/A	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	N/A	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +8.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Atlanta earns a B grade, with its 54.2th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros driven by severe labor market weakness, as evidenced by an unemployment rate in the bottom tier at the 19th percentile. The city's labor market is characterized by this weakness, but hourly earnings are increasing by 6.47% year-over-year, placing it in the 79th percentile. This indicates that employed individuals are seeing meaningful income gains, with wage growth being a notable aspect of the city's economy.

The labor force is growing slowly, at just 0.51% year-over-year, which constrains hiring capacity. Atlanta has a cost of living advantage, with a composite score of 1.52, ranking in the 74th percentile. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 8.5% year-over-year, to an average of 51 days. This slowdown is a sign of normalization, given the strong wage growth and affordable cost of living.

Atlanta offers a business environment with a skilled workforce and low costs, making it an attractive location for companies. The primary risk is the labor market's underlying weakness, which could limit the city's long-term growth potential and pose a challenge for businesses looking to expand or hire. With its unique combination of strengths and weaknesses, Atlanta presents a complex narrative for businesses to consider.

Sources: BLS LAUS / SAE · Census Bureau / FRED · Realtor.com / FRED · 85% Employment / 15% Housing composite

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #16 OF 50

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

B

AVERAGE

54.0th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	43
Unemployment	20% weight	89
Wage Growth	15% weight	57
Cost of Living	12% weight	70
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	11
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	23
Housing Access	5% weight	67
Office Economy	3% weight	57

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.7%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.1%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-16.0%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**38 days**	median, +8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Denver earns an overall grade of B, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.60% being the most important takeaway. This rate reflects a tight labor market, where businesses face significant hiring competition and workers have considerable leverage. The city's civilian labor force has contracted by 1.50% year-over-year, indicating a structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their headcount.

The low unemployment rate is paired with a shrinking labor force, which masks a shrinking workforce rather than just low layoffs. The city's housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 8.6% year-over-year to an average of 38 days, indicating a moderate buyer's market. Building permits have fallen by 15.96% year-over-year, which will tighten housing supply and put upward pressure on prices.

Denver offers businesses a highly competitive labor market, but with significant hiring challenges due to a shrinking workforce. The primary risk for businesses considering location in Denver is the potential for labor shortages and rising costs, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and hinder growth prospects.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #17 OF 50

Fresno

Fresno

B

AVERAGE

53.4th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	82
Unemployment	20% weight	0
Wage Growth	15% weight	89
Cost of Living	12% weight	54
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	87
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	15
Housing Access	5% weight	55
Office Economy	3% weight	4

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	8.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+8.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-22.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +10.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno earns an overall grade of B, with its 8.20% unemployment rate being the most critical issue. The city's nonfarm employment growth of 1.86% year-over-year and labor force growth of 1.87% year-over-year indicate a rapidly expanding market. This growth is driven by a strong hiring pipeline, with wage growth of 8.37% year-over-year, which is excellent for workers but presents a cost pressure for employers.

Fresno's housing supply is contracting, with building permits declining sharply by 22.67% year-over-year. The city's low professional and office worker concentration, ranking in the 4th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. This decline in building permits, combined with strong employment growth, indicates a housing supply squeeze is building, which could deteriorate affordability and workforce attraction.

The city's high unemployment rate and declining building permits pose significant challenges for businesses. Fresno offers a rapidly expanding market with a strong hiring pipeline, but businesses must carefully consider these factors when making location decisions. The tension between employment growth and housing supply constraints makes it essential for companies to weigh the benefits and risks of operating in Fresno, where a strong economy is offset by labor market and housing challenges.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

Memphis

Memphis

B

AVERAGE

53.2th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	8
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	74
Cost of Living	12% weight	98
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	77
Housing Access	5% weight	22
Office Economy	3% weight	2

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.0%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+6.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. **N/A** working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS **+19.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **62 days** median, +6.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns a B grade, ranking in the 53.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with its stagnant job market being the primary concern. The city's nonfarm employment growth is -0.35% year-over-year, while labor force growth is 1.36% and wage growth is 6.12%. This indicates a market where workers are being attracted, but job creation is lagging.

Memphis has a significant cost advantage, with a cost of living composite score of 0.51, making it one of the most affordable metros. This affordability, combined with strong wage growth, is a major draw for businesses and workers. The city's low concentration of office and professional workers, ranking in the 2nd percentile, poses a constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 6.9% year-over-year, indicating softening demand. Memphis offers businesses an attractive cost environment and a growing labor force, but the stagnant job market and potential demand erosion are primary risks. Businesses can navigate the city's complexities and capitalize on its advantages by carefully considering these factors and planning accordingly.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

B

AVERAGE

51.7th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	90
Unemployment	20% weight	49
Wage Growth	15% weight	11
Cost of Living	12% weight	2
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	51
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	98
Housing Access	5% weight	2
Office Economy	3% weight	87

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.0%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+0.7%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.7%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+195.1%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**24 days**	median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Jose earns a top grade due to its rapid job creation, with nonfarm employment growth at +1.69% year-over-year. The city's economy is further bolstered by an extremely high rate of building permits, up +195.09% year-over-year, indicating an aggressive expansion of the housing supply. This growth has led to a deepening affordability crisis, as the cost of living composite scores a mere 2nd percentile, making it one of the most expensive metros.

The city's strong employment growth contrasts with stagnant wage growth at +0.65% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier. Workers are not benefiting from the economic expansion, limiting consumer spending power. The housing market, with an average of 24 days on market, is slowing down, with days on market increasing by +9.1% year-over-year. This slowing market is a healthy normalization, given the strong employment growth and rising building permits, which will eventually ease affordability pressures.

San Jose offers businesses a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking in the 87th percentile. The city's strong economic momentum makes it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. However, the extremely high cost of living constrains talent acquisition and limits real consumer spending power, offsetting the benefits of the city's economic growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B

AVERAGE

50.7th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	63
Unemployment	20% weight	26
Wage Growth	15% weight	68
Cost of Living	12% weight	11
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	70
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	70
Housing Access	5% weight	41
Office Economy	3% weight	72

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+15.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +6.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

New York earns a B+ grade, with its strong labor market and solid wage growth being the most important takeaway. The city's nonfarm employment increased by 0.13% year-over-year, and its civilian labor force grew by 1.20% year-over-year. Hourly earnings rose by 5.47% year-over-year, supporting the city's healthy expansion.

The city's high cost of living, with a composite index score of 4.93, poses a significant constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. This is a key consideration, as it offsets the advantage of the city's above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 72nd percentile. The slowing housing market, with days on market increasing by 6.2% year-over-year, is a stabilizing force given the strong employment growth and rising building permits.

New York offers businesses a strong and expanding labor market, with solid wage growth and a highly skilled workforce. However, the high cost of living is the primary risk, constraining talent acquisition and consumer spending power. Businesses must carefully consider the trade-offs of operating in this market, weighing the benefits of the city's labor market against the drawbacks of its high cost of living.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #21 OF 50

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

B

AVERAGE

50.4th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	74
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	0
Cost of Living	12% weight	35
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	92
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	2
Housing Access	5% weight	82
Office Economy	3% weight	83

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-1.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-39.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	49 days	median, +13.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Charlotte earns a B grade, with its 50.4th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros driven by a strong hiring pipeline, as evidenced by a 2.28% year-over-year labor force growth rate. The city's nonfarm employment growth is above average, at 0.85% year-over-year. However, hourly earnings have declined by 1.28% year-over-year, a concerning sign for consumer spending.

The housing market is a concern, with building permits declining sharply by 39.50% year-over-year, indicating a potential housing supply squeeze. Homes are taking longer to sell, with days on market increasing by 13.9% year-over-year to an average of 49 days. This slowdown in the housing market, combined with declining building permits, indicates that demand is eroding.

Charlotte offers a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking in the 83rd percentile, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The primary risk is a potential housing supply squeeze, which could lead to affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties, ultimately undermining the city's economic growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #22 OF 50

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

B

AVERAGE

50.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	69
Unemployment	20% weight	28
Wage Growth	15% weight	55
Cost of Living	12% weight	13
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	81
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	55
Housing Access	5% weight	49
Office Economy	3% weight	49

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.4%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.6%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.7%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-0.4%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**38 days**	median, +5.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Diego earns an overall grade of B, with its strong labor market pipeline being the single most important takeaway about this city. The city's labor force growth is +1.66% YoY, ranking in the top tier at 81st percentile. Nonfarm employment growth is +0.70% YoY, above average. However, the unemployment rate is 4.40%, signaling labor market slack and weakened local consumer demand.

The cost of living in San Diego is a significant constraint, with a composite score of 4.90, placing it in the bottom tier at 13th percentile. This high cost of living limits the city's appeal for talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by +5.6% YoY to an average of 38 days.

San Diego's strong labor force growth and above-average employment growth make it an attractive location for businesses. However, the high cost of living and slowing housing market pose significant risks, constraining talent acquisition and consumer spending power. Businesses should carefully consider these factors when making location decisions, weighing the benefits of a strong labor market against the drawbacks of decreased affordability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.5th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	14
Unemployment	20% weight	45
Wage Growth	15% weight	92
Cost of Living	12% weight	37
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	77
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	87
Housing Access	5% weight	8
Office Economy	3% weight	68

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+8.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. **N/A** working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS **+41.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **74 days** median, +10.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Miami earns a grade of B- due to its stagnant employment growth, with nonfarm employment growth at -0.70% year-over-year. The city's job market is contracting, a significant concern, but wages are growing at +8.39% year-over-year, making existing jobs more lucrative. The housing market is expanding, with building permits up +41.11% year-over-year, which will help alleviate pressure on affordability.

The labor market's mixed health is characterized by stagnant employment growth and a slowing housing market, with days on market increasing by +10.4% year-over-year to 74 days. Miami's above-average cost of living, with a composite score of 3.14, means businesses must offer wage premiums to attract talent. The city has a strong office and professional worker share, ranking in the 68th percentile.

Miami offers businesses a highly skilled and expensive workforce, with a rapidly expanding housing supply that will help with long-term affordability. The primary risk is the city's stagnant employment growth and potential demand erosion, which will make it challenging for businesses to find and retain talent, and require them to offer higher wages to compete.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

Columbus

Columbus

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.4th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	22
Unemployment	20% weight	79
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	65
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	28
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	64
Housing Access	5% weight	86
Office Economy	3% weight	77

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.3%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+8.7%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**41 days**	median, +10.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus earns a B- grade, with its low unemployment rate of 3.60% being the single most important takeaway about this city. The city's labor force growth is 0.35% YoY and nonfarm employment growth is 0.29% YoY, indicating a constructive but challenging market. The cost of living is affordable, with a composite score of 1.84.

The housing market is slowing down, with days on market increasing by 10.8% YoY, and homes now sitting on the market for an average of 41 days. This slowdown, combined with weak employment growth, indicates demand erosion rather than healthy normalization. The office and professional worker share is above-average, ranking in the 77th percentile, which is a positive for office-dependent businesses.

Columbus offers a stable, albeit slow-growing, labor market and an affordable cost of living. However, the primary risk for businesses is the potential for demand erosion, driven by weak employment growth and a slowing housing market. Decision-makers should approach Columbus with caution, carefully weighing the city's advantages against its economic challenges, particularly in terms of hiring capacity and workforce supply, with the city ranking in the 49.4th percentile among 50 US metros.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

Cleveland

Cleveland

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.0th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	49
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	2
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	85
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	66
Housing Access	5% weight	39
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+11.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns a top-tier grade due to its strong and expanding labor force, with a year-over-year growth rate of 1.80%. This growth is not translating to wage increases, as hourly earnings have declined by 0.77% over the same period, indicating stagnant or declining real wages. The city's labor force is growing, but workers have limited leverage.

The housing market in Cleveland is characterized by mixed signals, with building permits increasing by 11.14% year-over-year and days on market increasing by 7.8% to an average of 55 days. This suggests a potential normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth, rather than a decline in demand. The strong labor force growth and above-average permit growth support this scenario.

Cleveland offers a growing and expanding labor force, but businesses should be aware of the potential risks of softening demand and limited workforce leverage. The declining wage growth and slowing housing market may impact consumer spending and demand, affecting the overall viability of the market. With a growing labor force and mixed housing market signals, businesses must carefully consider these factors when evaluating Cleveland as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.3th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	53
Unemployment	20% weight	19
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	57
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	60
Housing Access	5% weight	84
Office Economy	3% weight	60

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **N/A** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **N/A** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. **N/A** working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS **+4.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **43 days** median, +10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Philadelphia earns a B- grade, with its labor market weakness being the most significant concern. The city's unemployment rate ranks in the bottom tier, flagging potential consumer spending risks. The labor market is a significant concern, with the unemployment rate being a key indicator of this weakness.

The housing market is slowing, with homes taking 43 days to sell on average, a 10.3% increase year-over-year, indicating a slow and buyer-friendly market. Building permits are growing at a moderate pace of 4.14% year-over-year, but this does not provide a clear verdict on whether the market is stabilizing or softening.

Philadelphia's slow and buyer-friendly housing market could be beneficial for workers relocating to the area, but the primary risk is the city's labor market weakness, which indicates underlying economic softness and demand erosion. The city ranks 48.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, highlighting the need for closer investigation into its economic dynamics.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #27 OF 50

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.1th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	33
Unemployment	20% weight	55
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	72
Housing Access	5% weight	33
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.5%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**N/A**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.3%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+16.9%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**54 days**	median, +5.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Phoenix earns a B- grade, with its lackluster nonfarm employment growth being the most significant concern. The metro area ranks in the 48.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, driven by a 0.28% year-over-year decline in nonfarm employment, positioning it in the 33rd percentile. The housing market is characterized by a 16.86% year-over-year increase in building permits, but days on market have lengthened by 5.9% to an average of 54 days.

The rise in days on market, coupled with below-average employment growth, indicates a potential demand erosion scenario. Homes are taking more days to sell, even as new supply comes online, which suggests a genuine decline in demand rather than a healthy normalization. This narrative is reinforced by the lack of strong wage growth or labor force expansion, which would typically accompany a thriving economy.

Phoenix's slowing job market and potential demand erosion in the housing sector pose a risk to businesses considering relocation. The city's weakening economic foundation could impact the availability and quality of the workforce, making it a less attractive location for investment and growth. With a ranking in the 48.1th percentile, Phoenix's economic profile is a concern for businesses looking to invest in the area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

Providence

Providence-Warwick

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.1th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	71
Unemployment	20% weight	15
Wage Growth	15% weight	26
Cost of Living	12% weight	0
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	83
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	83
Housing Access	5% weight	94
Office Economy	3% weight	70

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+23.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	48 days	median, +33.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Providence earns a grade of C+ due to its severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 4.30% posing a high risk to consumer spending. The city's labor force growth is 1.69% year-over-year, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. Providence has a cost of living composite score of 7.36, ranking in the bottom tier, making it one of the most expensive metros and constraining talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

The city's housing supply is expanding aggressively, with building permits increasing by 23.50% year-over-year, a top-tier performance. Days on market have risen by 33.3% to 48 days, indicating a slow and buyer-friendly market. This slowdown is a stabilizing force, given the city's above-average employment growth of 0.60% and strong labor force expansion.

Providence offers a unique combination of a rapidly expanding workforce and an aggressively growing housing supply, but its high cost of living and labor market weakness pose significant risks. The city's expensive nature and unemployment rate outweigh its positives, making it a challenging location for businesses that rely heavily on consumer spending or require a large, affordable workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

47.4th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	35
Unemployment	20% weight	92
Wage Growth	15% weight	23
Cost of Living	12% weight	30
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	30
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	57
Housing Access	5% weight	78
Office Economy	3% weight	21

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.1%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE PART. **N/A** working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS **+3.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **45 days** median, +9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Louisville earns a B+ grade, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.10% being the most important takeaway about this city. This low rate indicates a competitive hiring environment where workers have leverage. The city's labor force growth is 0.38% YoY and nonfarm employment growth is -0.24% YoY, which constrains the labor market's strength due to a shallow pool of available workers.

The city's wage growth is 2.36% YoY, below average, which signals weak worker bargaining power or softening demand. The cost of living composite score is 3.37, below average, indicating that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 9.8% YoY to an average of 45 days.

Louisville offers a competitive labor market with low unemployment, but poses the risk of constrained hiring capacity due to a shallow labor pool. Businesses considering locating in Louisville must navigate a tight labor market with limited room for growth, requiring strategic recruitment and retention strategies to attract and retain top talent.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.8th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	37
Unemployment	20% weight	13
Wage Growth	15% weight	83
Cost of Living	12% weight	39
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	68
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	74
Housing Access	5% weight	33
Office Economy	3% weight	0

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**5.1%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+6.7%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.9%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**+18.0%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**54 days**	median, +5.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Riverside earns a B- grade, with labor market weakness being the most critical issue, as evidenced by an unemployment rate of 5.10% and below-average nonfarm employment growth of +0.88% YoY. The city's hourly earnings rose by +6.68% YoY, a top-tier performance indicating a competitive labor market. This contrast between labor market weakness and strong wage growth presents a complex economic landscape.

The cost of living is above average, with a composite score of 3.12, which, combined with rapid wage growth, pressures businesses to offer premium wages to attract talent. The office and professional worker share is remarkably low, ranking in the 0th percentile, posing a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by +5.9% YoY to 54 days, indicating softening demand in the face of weak employment growth.

Riverside's labor market weakness and high cost of living are the primary risks for businesses considering this location. The city's talented workforce is a benefit, but businesses must weigh this against the potential costs and challenges of attracting and retaining top talent in a competitive market. With an overall ranking in the 44.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, Riverside presents a unique set of challenges and opportunities for businesses to navigate.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.2th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	45
Unemployment	20% weight	2
Wage Growth	15% weight	96
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	17
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	53
Housing Access	5% weight	63
Office Economy	3% weight	66

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+9.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-0.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	34 days	median, +9.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Seattle earns a B+ grade, with its labor market weaknesses posing the most significant challenge to businesses. The city faces severe labor market challenges, with an unemployment rate of 5.00% and a shrinking civilian labor force, down 0.65% year-over-year. This structural headwind is a significant concern for businesses seeking to expand their headcount. Hourly earnings are rising 9.02% year-over-year, indicating a highly competitive labor market that poses cost pressures for employers.

Seattle boasts an above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 66th percentile. The housing market is slowing down, with a 9.7% year-over-year increase in days on market, and homes now taking 34 days to sell on average. This slowing market, combined with weak labor force growth and high unemployment, raises concerns about demand erosion.

The primary risk for businesses considering locating in Seattle is the city's labor market weaknesses, which limit their ability to expand and grow. Despite offering a highly skilled and competitive workforce, the city's rapidly rising wages and slowing housing market signal broader economic softness. Businesses must carefully weigh the costs and benefits of operating in this market, considering the trade-offs between a talented workforce and the challenges of a tight labor market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.2th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	84
Unemployment	20% weight	15
Wage Growth	15% weight	28
Cost of Living	12% weight	20
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	70
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	26
Housing Access	5% weight	65
Office Economy	3% weight	32

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.8%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.0%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-15.5%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**39 days**	median, +8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Sacramento earns an overall grade of B- and ranks in the 44.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with strong job creation being its most notable economic feature. The metro area has nonfarm employment growth of +1.00% YoY, placing it in the top tier. However, this is offset by a high unemployment rate of 4.80%, indicating labor market weakness.

The cost of living composite score of 4.25 makes Sacramento one of the most expensive metros, constraining talent acquisition and consumer spending power. The decline in building permits by -15.51% YoY, combined with the high cost of living, will exacerbate affordability issues and hinder workforce attraction. Homes now take an average of 39 days to sell, with days on market increasing by +8.3% YoY, indicating a moderating housing market.

The primary risk to Sacramento's attractiveness is a potential housing supply squeeze, driven by declining building permits and a high cost of living. This could undermine the area's appeal to workers and impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent. With a strong job creation environment, Sacramento offers opportunities for businesses, but these caveats must be carefully considered.

Sources: BLS LAUS / SAE · Census Bureau / FRED · Realtor.com / FRED · 85% Employment / 15% Housing composite

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #33 OF 50

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

C+

POOR

43.7th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	29
Unemployment	20% weight	49
Wage Growth	15% weight	36
Cost of Living	12% weight	91
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	79
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	4
Housing Access	5% weight	24
Office Economy	3% weight	28

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-37.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	61 days	median, +1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Antonio earns a grade of B+ due to its affordable cost of living, with a composite index score of 1.09. The city's labor force is growing at an above-average rate of +1.47% YoY, indicating a positive workforce supply. However, wage growth is sluggish at +3.43% YoY, signaling weak worker bargaining power or softening demand.

The housing market is experiencing a sharp decline in building permits, down -37.55% YoY, indicating a contracting housing supply. Homes take 61 days to sell on average, and the days on market have increased by +1.7% YoY, indicating a slowing market due to demand erosion. The city's professional talent pool ranks in the 28th percentile, which may constrain specialized or senior roles.

San Antonio's slowing economic growth, with a nonfarm employment growth rate of +0.43% YoY, poses a primary risk. The decline in building permits and slowing housing market may lead to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties. Businesses must carefully consider these factors when making location decisions, weighing the benefits of an affordable cost of living against the potential drawbacks of a slowing economy.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #34 OF 50

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

C+

POOR

43.3th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	24
Unemployment	20% weight	6
Wage Growth	15% weight	94
Cost of Living	12% weight	83
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	55
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	49
Housing Access	5% weight	10
Office Economy	3% weight	34

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+8.8%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.2%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-8.6%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**66 days**	median, +15.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Tampa earns a C+ overall grade, with its labor market weakness being the most significant concern. The city's unemployment rate of 4.60% indicates a labor market with considerable weakness, and the -0.22% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth signals economic deceleration. Hourly earnings have risen by 8.81% year-over-year, a top-tier performance that puts pressure on labor costs for employers.

Tampa's cost of living composite score of 1.41 makes it one of the most affordable metros, but the housing market is slowing. The days on market have increased by 15.8% year-over-year, with homes taking an average of 66 days to sell. This trend, combined with a below-average office and professional worker share, poses constraints for specialized or senior roles.

The city's strong wage growth amidst weak employment growth indicates a mix shift toward higher-paying jobs rather than broad labor market strength. Tampa offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a talented workforce with rising wages, but the primary risk lies in its labor market weakness and potential constraints in attracting specialized talent. The city's economic deceleration and slowing housing market demand careful consideration from decision-makers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

C+

POOR

42.5th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	6
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	64
Cost of Living	12% weight	89
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	26
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	79
Housing Access	5% weight	51
Office Economy	3% weight	17

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+20.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, +17.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City earns a grade of C due to its struggling labor market, with a nonfarm employment growth rate of -0.54% year-over-year. The city's labor force growth rate is 0.23% year-over-year, indicating a slow expansion of the workforce. This contraction in job opportunities ranks the city in the bottom 6th percentile.

The city's cost of living composite score of 1.11 places it in the top 89th percentile, making it one of the most affordable metros in the dataset. However, the low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 17th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 17.0% year-over-year and homes taking an average of 55 days to sell.

Oklahoma City's solid wage growth of 5.38% year-over-year is a positive note, but it is offset by labor market challenges. The city's affordability can be a strong draw for talent and investment, but the struggling labor market, with weak employment growth and a low concentration of professional workers, limits its appeal for certain types of businesses.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #36 OF 50

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

C+

POOR

42.0th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	18
Unemployment	20% weight	96
Wage Growth	15% weight	45
Cost of Living	12% weight	6
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	21
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	43
Housing Access	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	23

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**2.5%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.7%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-10.3%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**51 days**	median, +15.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood earns an overall grade of C+, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.50% being the most important takeaway. The city's low unemployment rate indicates a tight labor market, where businesses face significant hiring competition and workers have considerable leverage. The cost of living composite score of 5.25 places Indianapolis in the bottom tier, making it one of the most expensive metros, which can constrain talent acquisition and consumer spending power.

The labor force is growing slowly, with a year-over-year growth rate of -0.36%, resulting in a shallow pool of available workers. The high cost of living and limited professional talent pool, ranked in the 23rd percentile, exacerbate hiring challenges for specialized or senior roles. Nonfarm employment growth has declined by 0.66% year-over-year, indicating a stagnant job market.

The city's economic stagnation, coupled with its high cost of living, hinders a company's ability to attract and retain top talent, ultimately impacting its growth and competitiveness. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 15.9% year-over-year to an average of 51 days, indicating softening demand in the face of weak employment growth. Businesses must carefully consider these factors when making location decisions in Indianapolis.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

C+

POOR

41.4th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	26
Unemployment	20% weight	70
Wage Growth	15% weight	40
Cost of Living	12% weight	9
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	0
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	89
Housing Access	5% weight	88
Office Economy	3% weight	8

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	+55.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	44 days	median, +15.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Grand Rapids earns a C+ grade, with its low unemployment rate of 4.00% masking a concerning contraction in the civilian labor force, which has shrunk by 4.96% year-over-year. This indicates a shrinking workforce, rather than just low layoffs. The city's labor market is tight, but its workforce is declining.

The city has a high cost of living, ranking in the 9th percentile, making it one of the most expensive metros. The office and professional worker share is also in the bottom tier, ranking in the 8th percentile, posing a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. In contrast, the housing supply is expanding, with building permits increasing by 55.17% year-over-year.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market rising by 15.8% to an average of 44 days, and employment growth is weak at -0.43% year-over-year. This combination signals demand erosion. Businesses must be cautious of the high cost of living and the potential for demand erosion, with the constrained labor pool posing a primary risk to their ability to expand and grow.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

C+

POOR

40.1th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	67
Unemployment	20% weight	11
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	6
Housing Access	5% weight	12
Office Economy	3% weight	47

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.4%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**N/A**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.5%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-35.6%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**67 days**	median, +11.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Orlando earns a C+ overall grade, with its struggling labor market and housing supply constraints being the most significant concerns. The city's unemployment rate of 4.40% indicates a labor market weakness that will impact consumer spending. The sharp decline in building permits, down 35.64% year-over-year, contracts the housing supply, exacerbating affordability issues and hindering workforce attraction.

Orlando's nonfarm employment growth is a positive indicator, with a 0.46% year-over-year increase, signaling a healthy expansion. Homes are taking 11.7% more days to sell than last year, with an average of 67 days on market, due to softening demand. This trend is driven by the decline in building permits, posing a risk of demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization of the market.

Orlando offers a growing economy with above-average job growth, but its labor market weaknesses and housing supply constraints pose significant risks. The contracting housing supply and slowing market will cause affordability stress and relocation challenges, ultimately impacting businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

St. Louis

St. Louis

C+

POOR

38.8th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	10
Unemployment	20% weight	70
Wage Growth	15% weight	13
Cost of Living	12% weight	33
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	62
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	51
Housing Access	5% weight	90
Office Economy	3% weight	19

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.5%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+1.4%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.2%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-7.0%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**46 days**	median, +17.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of C+ and ranks in the 38.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with stagnant job growth being the primary concern. The city's labor market is characterized by nonfarm employment increasing by only 0.17% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier, and hourly earnings rising by just 1.41% year-over-year, also in the bottom tier. The unemployment rate is 3.50%, but this does not offset the overall labor market constraint.

The city's housing market is slowing, with homes taking 46 days to sell on average, and this duration increasing by 17.9% year-over-year. This trend indicates a shift towards a buyer's market, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the area. The low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 19th percentile, further constrains the city's appeal to knowledge-economy businesses.

St. Louis offers a cost of living with a composite score of 3.29, making it an affordable option. However, this advantage is offset by significant labor market and housing market risks, driven by weak job growth and a slowing housing market, which could undermine the city's economic stability and limit opportunities for growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C+

POOR

38.1th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	55
Unemployment	20% weight	19
Wage Growth	15% weight	34
Cost of Living	12% weight	17
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	28
Housing Access	5% weight	80
Office Economy	3% weight	51

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	N/A	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-15.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	30 days	median, +20.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Boston earns a C+ overall grade, with its high costs and labor market weakness being the most significant concerns. The city's unemployment rate of 3.90% indicates a labor market that is not absorbing workers as effectively as its peers. The cost of living composite score of 4.36 places Boston among the most expensive metros, constraining talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

The housing market in Boston presents a challenging picture, with days on market increasing by 20.0% year-over-year to an average of 30 days. This slowing pace of sales, combined with below-average building permit growth of -14.97% year-over-year, signals softening demand. Sluggish wage growth of +3.37% year-over-year also contributes to weakening demand, as workers have less disposable income to spend on housing and other goods.

Boston offers businesses a highly educated and skilled workforce, but at a high cost. The primary risk for businesses considering location in Boston is demand erosion, driven by high costs, labor market weakness, and a slowing housing market, which could impact consumer spending power and business growth. With these factors in mind, businesses must carefully weigh the benefits and drawbacks of operating in Boston.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C

VERY POOR

37.7th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	20
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	98
Cost of Living	12% weight	72
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	4
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	0
Housing Access	5% weight	14
Office Economy	3% weight	30

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+10.1%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.4%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-46.8%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**36 days**	median, -5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Virginia Beach earns a C grade, ranking 37.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, due to its struggling labor market. The civilian labor force has declined by 2.41% year-over-year, and nonfarm employment growth is below average at -0.41% year-over-year. This indicates a labor market with significant slack, impacting local consumer demand.

The metro area has top-tier wage growth, with hourly earnings rising by 10.08% year-over-year. This strong wage growth contrasts with the stagnant employment picture, indicating a shift towards higher-paying jobs rather than broad labor market health. The housing market is characterized by a sharp decline in building permits, down 46.79% year-over-year, and homes sell quickly in just 36 days.

Virginia Beach offers strong wage growth and an affordable cost of living, with a composite score of 1.59. However, labor market and housing supply constraints pose a risk to the area's long-term growth prospects. Businesses must carefully weigh these factors when considering the location, as the potential for constraints to limit growth is a primary concern, with the area's fast-moving housing market and declining labor force being key challenges.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C

VERY POOR

35.5th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	16
Unemployment	20% weight	83
Wage Growth	15% weight	38
Cost of Living	12% weight	22
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	2
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	40
Housing Access	5% weight	37
Office Economy	3% weight	13

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.1%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.5%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.8%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-10.5%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**33 days**	median, +6.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Milwaukee earns a B+ grade, with its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.10% being the most important takeaway about this city. This tight labor market indicates a highly competitive hiring environment where workers have significant leverage. The city's civilian labor force has contracted by 3.11% year-over-year, posing a structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their workforce.

The low concentration of office and professional workers, ranking in the 13th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The housing market, with homes selling in 33 days, is slowing down, with a 6.5% year-over-year increase in days on market, signaling softening demand in the context of weak employment growth. Nonfarm employment growth has stalled, with a -0.75% year-over-year change, pointing to a broader economic slowdown.

Milwaukee's labor market is constrained by a shrinking workforce and limited professional talent pool. The primary risk for businesses considering location in Milwaukee is the potential for demand erosion, driven by weak employment growth and a slowing housing market, which limits the city's ability to support long-term economic expansion. This risk is a key consideration for businesses evaluating Milwaukee as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C

VERY POOR

35.2th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	39
Unemployment	20% weight	23
Wage Growth	15% weight	17
Cost of Living	12% weight	44
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	38
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Housing Access	5% weight	57
Office Economy	3% weight	45

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	N/A	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	45 days	median, +7.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Detroit earns a C grade, with its sluggish labor market being the most important takeaway. The city's unemployment rate of 4.70% and stagnant wage growth of 1.58% year-over-year indicate a labor market with significant slack, weakening local consumer demand. The nonfarm employment growth of -0.16% year-over-year signals economic deceleration, a risk signal worth watching.

The housing sector reveals market tensions, with a 7.1% year-over-year increase in days on market, suggesting a slowing market. Weak employment growth and average building permits point to demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization. The stagnant labor force growth of 0.59% year-over-year and bottom-tier wage growth exacerbate these concerns, indicating a softening market with limited workforce leverage.

Detroit's labor market offers easier hiring due to its elevated unemployment rate, but this comes with the risk of weakened local consumer demand. The city's economic deceleration and potential demand erosion may impact long-term growth and stability, making it a primary caveat for businesses considering location in Detroit.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

C

VERY POOR

34.6th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	41
Unemployment	20% weight	19
Wage Growth	15% weight	15
Cost of Living	12% weight	59
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	43
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	34
Housing Access	5% weight	69
Office Economy	3% weight	6

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**N/A**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+1.5%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.1%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-12.2%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**36 days**	median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington earns an overall grade of C, reflecting a labor market with significant weaknesses, most notably its high unemployment rate and stagnant wage growth. The city's unemployment rate ranks in the 19th percentile, and wage growth is +1.47% YoY, placing it in the bottom tier. The office and professional worker share is also low, ranking in the 6th percentile, posing a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 9.1% YoY to an average of 36 days, and building permits declining by 12.25% YoY. This decline in building permits indicates that demand is eroding, rather than simply normalizing. The low office and professional worker share exacerbates this concern, limiting the city's ability to attract and retain high-skilled workers.

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington's labor market challenges and slowing housing market pose risks for businesses reliant on skilled workers. The city's potential for demand erosion and labor market weakness could hinder growth and competitiveness, making it a critical consideration for businesses evaluating this location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

C

VERY POOR

34.3th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	47
Unemployment	20% weight	30
Wage Growth	15% weight	47
Cost of Living	12% weight	46
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	8
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	13
Housing Access	5% weight	18
Office Economy	3% weight	36

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-27.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	35 days	median, -2.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Chicago earns a C grade, ranking 34.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with its labor market slack and rapidly tightening housing market posing significant risks to businesses. The city's unemployment rate of 4.50% signals a labor market with slack, making hiring easier, but also weakening local consumer demand. The civilian labor force is shrinking at a rate of -1.72% YoY, a significant structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand their headcount.

The housing market is characterized by supply contraction, with building permits declining sharply by -27.41% YoY, while homes are selling faster, with days on market averaging 35 days, a -2.8% YoY change. This indicates a thin-supply illusion, rather than genuine demand strength, as the market is heating up due to a lack of available homes. The rapid pace of home sales poses a significant relocation challenge for new hires, who will face intense competition for limited housing options.

Chicago's shrinking labor force and tight housing market pose significant risks to businesses, particularly in attracting and retaining talent. The city's below-average office and professional worker share constrains growth, and the intense competition for housing may outweigh any advantages of a slightly softer labor market. With a labor force decline and housing supply contraction, businesses must carefully consider these challenges when evaluating Chicago as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

C-

CRITICAL

31.9th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	4
Unemployment	20% weight	6
Wage Growth	15% weight	77
Cost of Living	12% weight	85
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	53
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	8
Housing Access	5% weight	29
Office Economy	3% weight	11

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+6.4%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.5%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-32.7%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**58 days**	median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville earns a grade of C due to its severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 4.60% and nonfarm employment growth of -0.49% year-over-year. The city's contraction story is further exacerbated by a sharp decline in building permits, down 32.70% year-over-year, indicating a housing supply that is contracting and leading to future affordability stress. Jacksonville boasts a significant cost advantage, with a cost of living composite score of 1.29, ranking in the top tier and making it one of the most affordable metros in the dataset.

The housing market is slowing down, with days on market increasing by 1.8% year-over-year to an average of 58 days. This slowdown, combined with weak employment growth and declining building permits, indicates a demand erosion scenario, where fewer qualified buyers are entering the market due to economic softness. The city's low professional and office worker concentration, ranking in the 11th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

Jacksonville's economic weaknesses, particularly its high unemployment rate and low professional worker concentration, outweigh its cost advantages, making it a challenging location for businesses that rely on a skilled and growing workforce. The city's strong wage growth of 6.38% year-over-year is a positive note, driven by a mix shift towards higher-paying jobs. Despite this, the primary risk is the city's struggling labor market and declining housing supply, which will lead to workforce attraction difficulties.

Richmond

Richmond

C-

CRITICAL

30.7th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	12
Unemployment	20% weight	49
Wage Growth	15% weight	62
Cost of Living	12% weight	24
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	13
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	19
Housing Access	5% weight	6
Office Economy	3% weight	74

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	N/A	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	-20.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, -11.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Richmond earns a grade of C due to its contractionary labor market, with a -0.36% year-over-year change in nonfarm employment growth and a -1.22% year-over-year decline in the civilian labor force. This results in job losses and a shrinking workforce, posing significant structural headwinds for businesses seeking to expand their operations. Richmond boasts solid wage growth of 5.36% year-over-year, which supports consumer spending but exerts cost pressure on businesses.

The city's housing market is complex, with building permits declining sharply by -20.27% year-over-year, contracting the housing supply and leading to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties. Homes are selling rapidly, with an average of 39 days on market and a -11.4% year-over-year change, indicating a fast-moving market that poses relocation challenges for new hires.

Richmond offers businesses a low-cost environment, with a cost of living composite score of 3.78. However, its shrinking labor force and potentially overheated housing market pose significant risks, making it essential for companies to carefully weigh the benefits and drawbacks of locating in Richmond, as they may face challenges in attracting and retaining talent.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

C-

CRITICAL

29.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	2
Unemployment	20% weight	30
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	63
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	19
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	36
Housing Access	5% weight	96
Office Economy	3% weight	26

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-1.5%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-11.1%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**37 days**	median, +27.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Baltimore earns a C- grade, with its struggling labor market being the primary concern, marked by a bottom-tier nonfarm employment growth of -1.46% YoY and a shrinking civilian labor force, down 0.62% YoY. This contraction has led to an elevated unemployment rate of 3.60%, signaling labor market slack and weakened local consumer demand. The city's labor market woes are a significant challenge for businesses.

The cost of living in Baltimore is affordable, with a score of 1.85, ranking in the 63rd percentile. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 27.6% YoY to an average of 37 days, indicating a slow and buyer-friendly market. This slowdown is a sign of demand erosion, given the weak employment growth and declining building permits, down 11.14% YoY.

Baltimore's slowing housing market and declining building permits exacerbate the risk posed by its struggling labor market, making it a challenging location for businesses seeking to expand and attract top talent. The city's professional talent pool ranks in the 26th percentile, posing constraints for businesses seeking specialized or senior roles. With a weak labor market and limited talent pool, businesses must carefully consider these factors when evaluating Baltimore as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

C-

CRITICAL

28.7th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	31
Unemployment	20% weight	21
Wage Growth	15% weight	19
Cost of Living	12% weight	56
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	6
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Housing Access	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.8%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+1.9%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**N/A**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**N/A**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**N/A**	median, N/A YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Washington D.C. earns a C- overall grade, with its labor market challenges being the most significant concern. The city's unemployment rate of 3.80% signals labor market slack, and its civilian labor force is shrinking at a rate of -1.82% year-over-year, presenting a significant structural headwind for businesses seeking to expand headcount. Wage growth is stagnant, with hourly earnings increasing by only 1.90% year-over-year, which weakens local consumer demand.

The city's housing market is extremely competitive, with homes selling quickly, as indicated by its bottom-tier days on market score. This creates a challenge for new hires, who may face serious housing competition, affecting affordability and relocation decisions. The combination of a shrinking labor force and a highly competitive housing market creates a complex environment for businesses to navigate.

The city's labor market has slack, making it easier for businesses to hire, but this comes with significant risks, including a shrinking labor force and stagnant wage growth. The highly competitive housing market poses a relocation challenge, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions, with a shrinking labor force and stagnant wage growth being key concerns.

Sources: BLS LAUS / SAE · Census Bureau / FRED · Realtor.com / FRED · 85% Employment / 15% Housing composite

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

D

EMERGENCY

22.8th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	4
Wage Growth	15% weight	60
Cost of Living	12% weight	61
Labor Force Part.	10% weight	23
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	21
Housing Access	5% weight	16
Office Economy	3% weight	15

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.9%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+5.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-1.8%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE PART.	**N/A**	working-age population
BUILDING PERMITS	**-18.1%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**49 days**	median, -3.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area earns an overall grade of D, driven by severe labor market weakness. This weakness is characterized by an unemployment rate of 4.90% and a nonfarm employment growth rate of -1.84% year-over-year, indicating job losses and a contracting economy. The labor force is growing at a pace of +0.04% year-over-year, constraining hiring capacity.

The housing market is characterized by homes selling at a rapid pace, averaging 49 days on market, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.9% in days on market. However, building permits have declined by -18.14% year-over-year, indicating a supply contraction. The low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 15th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro's severe labor market weaknesses and constrained housing supply pose significant risks to businesses. The city's competitive housing market and limited professional workforce may lead to talent attraction and retention challenges, making it essential for businesses to carefully weigh these factors in their location decision, considering the potential risks alongside any potential benefits.